

See also: The Geneva Conventions 152–155 ■ The Hague Conventions 174–177 ■ The Chemical Weapons Convention 276–277 ■ The Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention 288–289

The Tsar Bomba (“king of bombs”) was secretly detonated by the Soviets on an Arctic island. The explosion was about 1,500 times greater than those of Hiroshima and Nagasaki combined.

basis that full-scale use of nuclear weapons would completely destroy both attacker and defender, MAD suggests both sides build enough nuclear weapons to guarantee each side would be utterly annihilated if it launched its weapons. That way, neither side would ever dare strike first. Stanley Kubrick’s 1964 film *Dr. Strangelove* brilliantly satirized the dangers of this strategy.

The public was terrified by the possibility of an all-out nuclear war and the ensuing global destruction. Protest movements sprang up, most notably the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament (CND), and, in 1961, up to 50,000 from Women Strike for Peace marched against nuclear weapons in 60 US cities.

The Cuban Missile Crisis

International negotiations on nuclear disarmament had begun in 1958, and the United Nations (UN)



formed the Ten Nation Committee on Disarmament (TNCD) in 1960, which became the Eighteen Nation Committee (ENCD) in 1961, but progress was limited. The tipping point came after a series of nuclear near-misses. In 1961, for example, the US accidentally dropped nuclear bombs on Goldsboro, North Carolina, that were a hair away from detonating. However, it was the 13-day Cuban Missile Crisis of October 1962 that provided the final wake-up call. The USSR was building nuclear launch sites in Cuba, just 90 miles (145 km) from the US coast. When US air forces spotted them, President John F. Kennedy retaliated with a naval blockade around Cuba. Nuclear war seemed imminent.

Kennedy and Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev pulled back from the brink: the USSR dismantled its Cuban sites and the US removed

its naval blockade. Horror at what might have happened pushed Kennedy and Khrushchev to the negotiating table. Khrushchev argued for a comprehensive ban on nuclear tests, but Kennedy could not get the US military to agree. His advisers wanted Soviet troops to withdraw from Cuba as a precondition of talks, while the USSR feared that the proposed verification inspections were »



President John F. Kennedy in 1962 addresses the American public on television to explain the threat from Soviet missile sites in Cuba and why the US Navy was blockading the island.

“
We will not ... risk
worldwide nuclear war ...
in which even the fruits
of victory would be
ashes in our mouth.
John F. Kennedy
35th US president (1961–1963),
address to the nation, 1962
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